The chief of intelligence himself was or was not aware of the extremely precise details that a female intelligence officer had forwarded about Hamas's preparations for an attack. She observed and analyzed all the methods they used to avoid any Israeli suspicion of some unusual behavior. We shall know soon enough whether her repeated warnings reached the top or remained stuck in the intelligence bureaucracy.

Friday, November 24

The first group of thirteen Israeli hostages was freed today. The event was broadcast from its very beginning on both radio and television. The emotion in Israel is immense. All ten hostages from Thailand and one from the Philippines were also freed.

Much has changed in the country since October 7. From what I hear from any number of friends who are there or have visited over the last few days, the major change is in the loss of a sense of security. The previous feeling of total normality was probably foolhardy, but what else could be expected? The majority of Israelis lived in relative economic well-being, owned a house or at least an apartment, took vacations in Eilat or Greece, and often further afield, etc. This sense of total normality was reinforced by a leadership that was, like the Netanyahu family, living the good life to the full. The normalization of the relations with the Gulf states and Morocco, and the possibility of a normalization of relations with Saudi Arabia strengthened the sense that the traditional security problems had been solved. Most Israelis were involved, over the last few months, in the internal conflicts that I've discussed here. October 7 has radically changed all of that. The insecurity felt by many is deeper than the bouts of anxiety that occurred after the previous wars. There is war in the South and in the North. There is growing restlessness among the Palestinians of the West Bank. There is the deadly hatred of the ayatollahs not far away. There isn't